

Coping intelligence theory: coping strategies, satisfaction and sales commission

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Abstract

Purpose – This study aims to develop and test a new formative theory of coping intelligence (CI). It asserts that problem- and emotion-focused coping strategies contribute differently to the overall CI latent construct, which, in turn, relates to three outcome variables – job satisfaction, life satisfaction and sales commission.

Design/methodology/approach – The study collected data from multiple sources: survey data from 452 boundary-spanning salespeople and sales commission from a company's personnel record. It then investigated the goodness of fit between the study's theoretical SEM model and empirical data.

Findings – Problem-focused coping and emotion-focused coping strategies, respectively, define CI positively and negatively. This, in turn, is related to high levels of job satisfaction, life satisfaction and sales commission. After controlling for gender and sales commission, results remain significant. Commission is related to satisfaction. Gender (male) is negatively related to emotion-focused strategy, but positively related to commission. Males have higher sales commission than females, yet both genders have similar life and job satisfaction.

Practical implications – Problem-focused coping contributes to life satisfaction, job satisfaction and sales commission, but emotion-focused coping undermines them. Researchers and policymakers need to develop training programs, promote problem-focused coping strategies and help them improve life satisfaction, job satisfaction and sales commission, for females, in particular.

Originality/value – CI is more related to job satisfaction and life satisfaction than to commission. The study's concurrent validity demonstrates that CI improves sales commission (objective data) and employee satisfaction. It pays to improve CI.

Keywords Job satisfaction, Coping, Stress, Life satisfaction, Coping intelligence, Sales commission

Paper type Research paper

If you ask what the single most important key to longevity is, I would have to say it is avoiding worry, stress and tension. And if you didn't ask me, I'd still have to say it. – The late comedian George Burns, who lived to 100

If you don't think your anxiety, depression, sadness and stress impact your physical health, think again. All of these emotions trigger chemical reactions in your body, which can lead to inflammation and a weakened immune system. Learn how to cope, sweet friend. There will always be dark days. Kris Carr (Bestselling Author)

1. Introduction

The National Institute of Occupational Safety and Health defines stress as “harmful physical and emotional responses that occur when the requirements of the job do not match the capabilities, resources, or needs of the worker” (National Institute of Occupational Safety and Health, 2016). Stress is a weapon of mass destruction. In fact, three out of every four employees describe their work as stressful (AIS, 2016). The World Health Organization called stress the “Health epidemic of the 21st century” (Said, 2016). It contributes to 120,000

deaths every year (Blanding, 2015). Stress is estimated to cost businesses up to \$300 billion a year (Smith, 2012). Workplace stress is responsible for \$190 billion in US health care cost alone (Blanding, 2015).

Organizations rely on the most valuable resource, their employees, to solve problems and successfully achieve financial goals. As customer demands are increasingly diverse, boundary-spanning employees – i.e. sales personnel – who make direct contact with the public or employees of other firms, must develop novel strategies to increase efficiency, effectiveness and local responsiveness to meet customer expectations and enhance their service satisfaction, performance quality and sales revenue (Eisingerich *et al.*, 2014; Jiang *et al.*, 2017). Stress, work-related stress, in particular, affects boundary spanners' satisfaction – life satisfaction and job satisfaction (Srivastava and Sager, 1999; Tang *et al.*, 2017; Tang and Hammontree, 1992). These boundary spanners play an important role in the success of the organizations (Edmondson and Boyer, 2013; Jolson *et al.*, 1993; Singh, 1993; Singh *et al.*, 1996) as they bridge the gap between the customer's need and their company's products. They interact with the customers, develop a relationship of trust and

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credibility and make the sales. This makes them extremely important to the company.

Boundary spanners, by definition, have to endure pressures from both outside and inside the company (Goolsby, 1992; Pruden and Reese, 1972) and deliver quality products and services, enhance customer satisfaction and improve firm performance (Hartline and Ferrell, 1996; Mulki *et al.*, 2012). Thereby, they constantly face a very high level of work-related stress (Schwepker and Ingram, 2016) with which they must continuously cope (Hamwi *et al.*, 2011). This is why it is critical to study the relationship of coping strategies and stress among boundary spanners and identify potential ways to reduce daily stress.

Research shows that some salespeople cope with stress better than others. “Coping behavior is a major component in the relationship between the experience of stress and adaptation outcomes such as poor psychological health and physical symptoms” (Oakland and Ostell, 1996, p. 133). There are various ways of coping with stress (Ivancevich and Matteson, 1986; Lewin and Sager, 2008; Moos, 1993). Folkman and Lazarus (1988) were the first researchers to identify and measure two main types of coping; problem-focused coping (PFC) and emotion-focused coping (EFC). Carver *et al.* (1989) identified three types of coping strategies: PFC, EFC and dysfunctional coping (mental and behavioral disengagement). However, subsequent scholars used only two types of coping and did not use the dysfunctional coping (Boyd *et al.*, 2009; Srivastava and Sager, 1999; Strutton and Lumpkin, 1993, 1994; Strutton *et al.*, 1995) because dysfunctional coping is very similar to the EFC. In this research, we follow suggestions in the literature and study PFC and EFC only, but not the dysfunctional coping [1].

Recently, Tang and his associates developed the notion of monetary intelligence (MI; Chen *et al.*, 2014; Gentina *et al.*, 2017; Sardžoska and Tang, 2012, 2015; Tang *et al.*, 2017; Tang, 2016; Tang and Sutarso, 2013; Tang *et al.*, 2015, 2016):

Monetary Intelligence, a form of social intelligence, is defined as the extent to which individual monitor their own monetary motive, behavior, and cognition; apply the information to evaluate critical concerns and options; select strategies to achieve financial goals; and reach ultimate success and subjective well-being (Tang, 2016, p. 583).

Individuals with positive stewardship behavior have high intrinsic and extrinsic job satisfaction. Positive affective motive such as the love of money and stewardship behavior are significantly related to their stronger behavioral and cognitive “approach” coping strategies and weaker “avoidance” coping strategies (Sardžoska and Tang, 2015). However, there is very little, or no overarching theory regarding coping intelligence (CI).

In this study, we define CI as the extent to which individuals monitor their own coping strategies, evaluate critical concerns and options, select proper strategies and achieve ultimate success – i.e. financial goals, satisfaction and subjective well-being. We briefly define constructs of our theoretical model below.

First, PFC involves individuals’ examinations of the sources of the problem (stress), generating alternatives, weighing the alternatives in terms of costs and benefits to self and organization and selecting an alternative based on the balance between costs and benefits (Tang *et al.*, 1987, 1989). Second,

EFC involves salespersons taking care of their emotions by regulating and reducing emotional distress (Folkman *et al.*, 1986; Goolsby, 1992; Jex *et al.*, 2001; Srivastava and Tang, 2015; Strutton and Lumpkin, 1993, 1994; Strutton *et al.*, 1995). Further, positive affective attitudes and behavioral actions are significantly related to their “approach” coping strategies and weaker “avoidance” coping strategies (Sardžoska and Tang, 2015). PFC strategy is similar to “approach” coping strategy, whereas EFC strategy is closely related to “avoidance” coping strategy. Thereby, we theorize that PFC strategies contribute positively, while EFC strategies contribute negatively, to the CI latent construct, which, in turn, may lead to high levels of job satisfaction, life satisfaction and sales commission (Figure 1). As gender and sales commission are related to constructs of our model, we control these variables in our analyses.

Our novel discoveries, based on data collected from multiple sources (survey and personnel records), support our theory of CI and provide the following theoretical contributions. Interestingly, PFC and EFC strategies are negatively correlated. PFC strategy contributes *positively* but EFC strategy contribute *negatively* to CI, which, in turn, positively guides employees to high levels of job satisfaction, life satisfaction and sales commission.

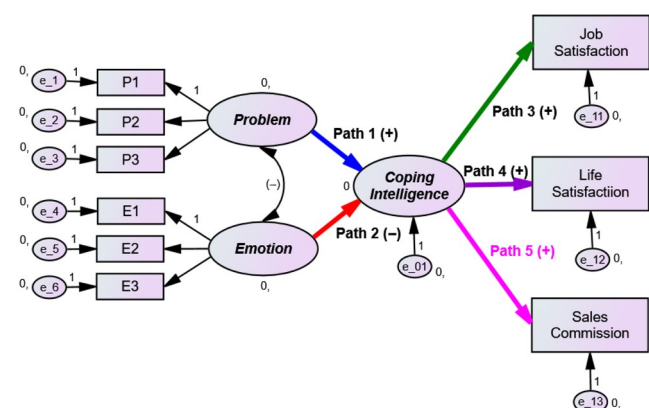
Treating gender and sales commission as control variables in separate analyses offers additional insights: Gender (males) is negatively related to EFC, positively related to sales commission and unrelated to life and job satisfaction. Sales commission is positively related to life and job satisfaction, but unrelated to coping strategies. After controlling gender and sales commission, all relationships remain significant. This study sheds new lights on boundary-spanning employees’ CI, satisfaction, gender and sales commission (objective performance) and offers practical implications to business and industrial marketing.

2. Literature review

2.1 Job stress and coping

Sales people provide source of revenue for the organization and bridge the gap between the organization and customers (Purani and Sahadev, 2008). Owing to their boundary-spanning position and customer demands (Goolsby, 1992), daily stress

Figure 1 Formative theoretical model



affects salespeople. In studying stress, person–environment fit theory (Chabra, 2016; Brewer and McMahan, 2004; Edwards, 1996; Edwards and Cooper, 1990) states that the levels of stress are associated with the level of interactions with the work environment (stimulus response paradigm). If the demands of the job are higher than the capabilities of the sales person, then that individual is likely to experience occupational stress (Chabra, 2016; Edwards, 1996; Edwards and Cooper, 1990). Stress, if not handled properly, leads to poor work performance, low job satisfaction and low life satisfaction (Hayes and Weathington, 2007; Howell *et al.*, 1987; Lewin and Sager, 2009; Morris and Long, 2002). In reaction to stress, some salespeople adopt different coping strategies and manage their job stress better than others (Behrman and Perrault, 1984; Lazarus and Folkman, 1984; Strutton and Lumpkin, 1993, 1994). Researchers have identified coping strategies that yield positive outcomes – high sales performance, life satisfaction and job satisfaction, for salespeople in organizations.

Lack of ability to cope with the stress causes poor performance, low job satisfaction, high burnout, high absenteeism and high illness (Tang and Hammontree, 1992). However, boundary spanner's successful coping strategies may increase their satisfaction with the organization and with life in general. Job satisfaction is a widely studied variable owing to its high significant relationships with common management variables such as role ambiguity, role conflict, turnover and performance (Brown and Peterson, 1993; Rich, 1997; Srivastava and Rangarajan, 2008; Tang *et al.*, 2000). Research on work–life conflict and life satisfaction is gaining more importance as employees' life is getting more stressful than before (Frone *et al.*, 1992; Tang *et al.*, 2015).

2.2 Coping strategies

The active coping process helps salespeople reduce chronic job stress and leads to positive outcomes: high job satisfaction and life satisfaction (Edwards, 1988, 1992; Folkman *et al.*, 1986). Folkman and Lazarus' (1988) seminal research identified two coping strategies: PFC (active coping) and EFC (avoidance coping; Lazarus and Folkman, 1984; Srivastava and Sager, 1999). Various scholars have adopted this approach (Edwards, 1988; Goolsby, 1992; Jex *et al.*, 2001; Strutton and Lumpkin, 1993, 1994; Strutton *et al.*, 1995). We define CI as a formative latent construct with both PFC and EFC as antecedents.

In PFC, salespeople identify the sources of stress, actively remove it and promote positive outcomes, e.g. lower burnout, lower withdrawal intentions, higher job satisfaction and higher performance. PFC makes it easier for employees to not only reduce their frustration with their job (Subramanian and Kumar, 2012) and daily stress but also enhance higher job performance and job satisfaction (Atteya, 2012; Sardžoska and Tang, 2012). Muse *et al.*'s (2003) meta-analysis supported a negative relationship between job stress and job performance. PFC substantially reduces job stress and improves job performance, which leads to higher job satisfaction and probably higher life satisfaction.

Employees frequently adopt the avoidance strategy and attempt to escape the stress. EFC leads to negative outcomes; e.g. lower job satisfaction, lower job performance, higher burnout and higher withdrawal intentions (Lewin and Sager, 2008; Srivastava and Sager, 1999). Evasive coping behavior

increases emotional exhaustion and lower sense of pride at work. When external pressure or stress increases, originality decreases (Grant, 2016), “when creativity is under the gun, it usually ends up getting killed” (Amabile *et al.*, 2002, p. 52). These employees with high levels of stress do not contribute their share to the company's performance and do not handle their work-related activity well, leading to lower job satisfaction and lower life satisfaction (Chuang and Huang, 2013; Sardžoska and Tang, 2012). Stress also has a devastating effect on employee's job performance. In an unpleasant work environment, employees spend a great deal of their time coping with this stress. EFC leads to poor performance and poor life satisfaction (Atteya, 2012).

2.3 Coping intelligence

Our formative CI model investigates the relationships between two antecedents – PFC and EFC and three outcome variables, life satisfaction, job satisfaction and sales commission (discussed later). Job stress has negative impacts on performance and satisfaction (Hayes and Weathington, 2007; Morris and Long, 2002). Two types of coping strategies (Edwards, 1992; Folkman and Lazarus, 1988; Lazarus and Folkman, 1984; Oakland and Ostell, 1996) have different consequences related to life satisfaction and job satisfaction. Successful coping behavior leads to higher job satisfaction (Chuang and Huang, 2013) and higher life satisfaction. The use of EFC, on the other hand, may lead to poor behaviors on the job and a lower job satisfaction and life satisfaction (Srivastava and Rangarajan, 2008). We present our dependent variables, next.

2.4 Life satisfaction and job satisfaction

Life satisfaction is “a judgmental process, in which individuals assess the quality of their lives on the basis of their own unique criteria” (Pavot and Diener, 1996, p. 164). Life satisfaction deals with various aspects of one's quality of life or the overall satisfaction of life (Diener *et al.*, 1985; Tang, 1992, 2007; Tang *et al.*, 2015). Job satisfaction is defined as a pleasurable emotional state resulting from the appraisal of one's job (Locke, 1969). It is a complex reaction to all aspects of the job (Del Vecchio, 1996; Hartman *et al.*, 2016). Work-related stress may result in employees' illness, absenteeism and propensity to leave (Hamwi *et al.*, 2014; Johnson *et al.*, 2000; Tang and Hammontree, 1992). Stress has a negative effect on the employees' emotional state and, thus, reduces job satisfaction and life satisfaction (Arndt and Harkins, 2013; Barnes *et al.*, 2006; Dorman and Zapf, 2001; Mayo and Mallin, 2014).

Following Herzberg's (1966, 1987) Motivation–Hygiene Theory, elements leading to satisfaction and dissatisfaction are different. First, motivators enrich a person's job, which include achievement, recognition, work itself, responsibilities and advancements. These motivators lead to job satisfaction and also life satisfaction because they satisfy an individual's needs for self-esteem and self-actualization (Stringer *et al.*, 2011; Tang, 2007; Tang *et al.*, 2015). Second, hygiene factors consist of company policy and administration, supervision–technical, salary, interpersonal relations–supervision and working conditions. The presence of these factors results in job dissatisfaction (Darmody and Smyth, 2016). Yet the absence of these hygiene factors will only lead to no job dissatisfaction.

Taken together, we explore CI and investigate the relationship between coping strategies and satisfaction with job and life. As coping strategies are related to individuals' job more directly than life, it is plausible that CI may have a higher impact on job satisfaction than life satisfaction.

2.5 Sales commission

Relationships between stress and performance exist (Atteya, 2012). Stress diminishes performance for some but enhances it for others. Boundary spanners who use a PFC, reduce stress and have higher job performance; those with an EFC have lower job performance (Clarke, 2006; Compas *et al.*, 2001). Individuals with high performance also have high job satisfaction (Brown and Peterson, 1993; Holmes and Srivastava, 2002). Job satisfaction is significantly and positively connected with salespeople's productivity (Boles *et al.*, 2007; Judge *et al.*, 2002; Loveland *et al.*, 2015).

Achieving high sales volume is strongly associated with company's financial success (Küster and Canales, 2011) and sales personnel's sales commission. Sales commission has been used as one of the measures of sales performance by researchers (Babakus *et al.*, 1996; Cravens *et al.*, 1993; Singh and Das, 2013). We assert that CI will enhance sales commission. In summary, we have two subjective outcomes (life satisfaction and job satisfaction) and one objective outcome (sales commission)[2]. As sales commission is related to company success and employee satisfaction, we will also treat sales commission as a control variable. As a control variable, we assert that sales commission is strongly related to other outcomes – job satisfaction and life satisfaction – than the antecedents of CI:

- H1. Individuals with high coping intelligence have high job satisfaction.
- H2. Individuals with high coping intelligence have high life satisfaction.
- H3. Individuals with high coping intelligence have high sales commission.
- H4. Sales commission (control) is related to life satisfaction and job satisfaction.

2.6 Gender

Since early childhood, boys and girls pursue fundamentally different paths in their socialization processes (Gentina *et al.*, 2017). Overall, men pursue masculine identity (agentic goal) and pay attention to assertiveness, self-assertion, dominance, competition, status and popularity. Women are concerned with feminine identity (communal goal), which focuses on social relationships, intimacy, cooperation, belonging and affiliation. Some researchers found positive effects of gender on coping (Akram and Mehmood, 2013; Hampel and Petermann, 2005), while others found little or no effect (Staempfli, 2007). Thus, the results are mixed. Taken together, we assert that owing to differences in gender-related socialization processes, men may focus on PFC strategies (high task orientation), whereas females pay attention to EFC strategies (strong people-orientation).

Researchers have debated the effects of gender on job satisfaction (Bender *et al.*, 2005; Kim, 2005; Linz and Semykina, 2013; Okpara *et al.*, 2005). Despite the tendency of women tend to earn lower wages and face fewer promotion opportunities, most argue that women are more satisfied than men (Clark, 1997; Luna-Arocas and Tang, 2004, 2015; Sloan and Williams, 2000; Tang, 1996; Tang *et al.*, 2003; Tang and Talpade, 1999; Tang *et al.*, 2006a). Others argue that men are more satisfied than women (Dalton and Marcis, 1987). Still some suggest no significant gender differences (Bilgic, 1998; Tait *et al.*, 1989). On the basis of our literature review, it is plausible that gender is more related to the antecedents of CI than outcome variables of CI (job satisfaction and life satisfaction). We treat gender as a control variable in our theoretical model and explore the hypothesis below:

- H5. As a control variable, females (gender) are significantly related to emotion-focused coping strategies, but males are not.

3. Theoretical model (reflective vs formative models)

Recently, researchers have explored both reflective and formative structural equation modeling (SEM) models (Williams *et al.*, 2003). SEM allows us to simultaneously examine latent constructs, observable items, measurement errors and relationships among constructs and items. We briefly introduce reflect and formative models below. In a reflect model, researchers treat items, indicators or subconstructs as imperfect reflections of the underlying latent construct. Direct manipulation of a particular indicator will not have an effect on the latent variable. The direction (arrow) of the relationship flows from the latent construct to its subconstructs and from subconstructs to indicators/items.

In this study, our formative model treats PFC and EFC strategies as distinguishable perspectives, non-interchangeable defining characteristics or formative indicators of the latent construct (CI). The elimination of any single subconstruct will restrict the overall construct in a significant way. A subconstruct emits arrows to its indicators/items. The direction (arrow) of the relationship flows from subconstructs to the latent construct and to outcome variables. The latent construct “is nothing more than a label for its dimensions considered collectively” (Edwards, 2011, p. 384).

To achieve model identification, a formative construct must emit paths to at least two unrelated latent constructs with reflective indicators, theoretically appropriate reflective indicators or one reflective indicator and one latent construct with reflective indicators. Paths emanating from a misspecified construct may lead to Type I errors, whereas paths leading to a misspecified construct may lead to Type II errors (Jarvis *et al.*, 2003). We adopt three theoretically appropriate outcome variables: life satisfaction and job satisfaction (subjective measures) and sales commission (objective measure from personnel records). We use rectangular boxes to represent observable indicators (P1, P2, P3, E1, E2, E3, job satisfaction, life satisfaction and sales commission) and oval-shaped circles to indicate unobserved latent constructs (problem, emotion, Ci and all measurement errors).

4. Methodology

4.1 Sample

We selected salespersons from the domestic sales force of an international manufacturer of specialty chemical products in the USA. Regarding sales workforce in this organization, we collected qualitative data by interviewing several sales managers. This large firm sells industrial maintenance chemicals, specialty lubricants and other supply items. Salespeople targeted building engineers and others authorized personnel to purchase \$5,000–\$10,000 of specialty chemicals per year. They refer this sales process as the back-door selling. The company compensates them through a commission system. Further, regarding sale personnel learning curves, it takes three to six months for these sales employees to achieve basic proficiency and 12 to 18 months to reach full proficiency on the job. This organization, at the time of our study, used 1,200 salespeople, and 100 sales managers arrayed into several geographic divisions. Although 25 per cent of salespeople were females, they represented about 40 per cent of new hires. The majority of salespeople (80 per cent) had a college degree or had partially completed college. The retention rate was slightly below 50 per cent, annually.

To collect data, we mailed a ten-page, self-administered questionnaire to all 1,200 salespeople's home address. The survey package consists of letters from the senior vice-president in charge of sales and the lead researcher, summarizing the rationale of this research project, assurance of confidentiality and their personal identity, a reference to a tracking number on the survey and encouragement of their survey completion. We applied the tracking number to match survey responses to objective performance (sales commission) from the company's official personnel records. Employees used a self-addressed postage-paid envelope and sent the completed survey to the lead researcher at the university. A total of 452 salespeople completed the survey (return rate = 37.67 per cent; males = 323, 72 per cent; females = 123, 28 per cent, with missing data). Compared to the whole organization, our sample seemed to have longer organizational tenure than the population. In fact, 54 per cent of respondents had worked for the company for five or more years. We take the advantage of these salespeople's relatively long tenure and examine their coping strategies, job and life satisfaction, gender and objective commission in this study.

4.2 Measure

We collected data from multiple sources: survey questionnaire and sales commission (firm's personnel record). For the survey, we selected PFC and EFC from Ways of Coping Checklist (Folkman and Lazarus, 1988). We adopt a five-point Likert-type scale with the following scale anchors: *almost never* (1) to *almost always* (5). A higher score suggests a greater usage of the coping strategy. See Appendix for items and constructs of all measures. We measured job satisfaction using Brayfield and Rothe's (1951) five-point Likert scale with *strongly disagree* (1) and *strongly agree* (5) as scale anchors. For life satisfaction, we adopted Diener *et al.*'s (1985) "Satisfaction with Life Scale", using a five-point Likert scale with *strongly disagree* (1) and *strongly agree* (5) as scale anchors. The reliability (Cronbach's alpha) is presented as follows (see Table I): PFC ($\alpha = 0.78$), EFC ($\alpha = 0.65$), life satisfaction ($\alpha = 0.89$) and job satisfaction ($\alpha = 0.86$). We calculated the mean for each construct.

5. Results

5.1 Descriptive statistics

Table I shows the mean, standard deviation, Cronbach's alpha and correlations of all variables at the subconstruct level. Results showed that salespeople's average age was 44.82 years old (with 84 per cent male). Both life satisfaction and job satisfaction were positively related to PFC and sales commission, but negatively related to EFC.

Table II shows that our overall MANOVA on coping strategies across gender was significant ($F(6, 471) = 3.171, p = 0.005$, Wilk's Lambda = 0.961, partial eta squared = 0.039, observed power = 0.923). Further, ANOVA results revealed: Females had significantly higher scores for the following two items of EFC than males: "miracles will happen" (Female = 2.27 vs Male = 1.84) and "have fantasies about how things work out" (Female = 2.63 vs Male = 2.33, $ps < 0.05$). The second overall MANOVA showed no significant differences in life satisfaction and job satisfaction across gender [$F(2, 484) = 0.385, p = 0.680$, Wilks' Lambda = 0.998, partial eta square = 0.002, observed power = 0.112]. We did not include sales commission in our MANOVA owing to different nature of these measures [3]. Further ANOVA revealed that both males and females had insignificant differences in life satisfaction (Females = 2.90 vs Males = 2.95) and job satisfaction (Females = 3.83 vs Males = 3.89). Results of standardized sales commission (z score) across gender showed that males ($M = 0.291$) had a significant higher level of sales commission ($F(1, 348) = 7.14, p < 0.008$) than females ($M = -0.080$). In

Table I Mean, standard deviation, correlations and reliability among major variables

Variables	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	1	2	3	4	5	6
1 Age	44.82	11.13						
2 Gender (% Male)	0.84	0.95	0.16**					
3 Problem-focused coping	3.72	0.64	0.02	−0.05	(0.77)			
4 Emotion-focused coping	2.24	0.90	−0.05	−0.01	−0.10**	(0.65)		
5 Life satisfaction	3.40	0.64	0.09*	0.04	0.31**	−0.14**	(0.86)	
6 Job satisfaction	3.87	0.68	0.16**	0.02	0.38**	−0.27**	0.43**	(0.89)
7 Sales commission	11,946.00	8,297.00	0.10	0.06	0.05	0.07	0.18**	0.11*

Notes: Gender: Male = 1, Female = 0. Construct reliability is presented in a pair of parentheses * $p < 0.05$ and ** $p < 0.01$

Table II MANOVA and ANOVA results

Variable	Female		Male		F	ANOVA df	p
	M	SD	M	SD			
1. Coping							
Work efficiently	3.98	0.73	4.00	0.72	0.12	1, 476	0.73
Devote time and energy	3.51	0.87	3.59	0.93	0.62	1, 476	0.45
Done and explain the affected	3.66	0.84	3.54	1.06	1.42	1, 476	0.23
Miracle will happen	2.27	1.32	1.84	1.23	11.53	1, 476	0.00*
Forget the whole thing	2.34	1.09	2.36	1.19	0.03	1, 476	0.86
Fantasies how things work out	2.63	1.22	2.33	1.22	5.67	1, 476	0.02*
2. Satisfaction							
Life satisfaction	3.36	0.62	3.41	0.65	0.45	1, 487	0.50
Job satisfaction	3.82	0.68	3.89	0.67	0.65	1, 487	0.42

Notes: Coping MANOVA: $F(6, 471) = 3.171$, $p = 0.005$, Wilk's Lambda = 0.961, partial eta squared = 0.039, observed power = 0.923; Satisfaction MANOVA: $F(2, 484) = 0.385$, $p = 0.680$, Wilks' Lambda = 0.998, partial eta square = 0.002, observed power = 0.112, * $p < 0.05$

summary, there were gender differences in coping strategies and sales commission, but no differences in satisfaction.

5.2 Evaluation criteria

We adopted the following rule to evaluate our measurement models. A measurement model has a good fit, if results pass four of the following five criteria: $\chi^2/df < 5$, incremental fit index (IFI) > 0.90 , Tucker–Lewis Index (TLI) > 0.90 , comparative fit index (CFI) > 0.90 and root mean square error of approximation (RMSEA) < 0.10 (Vandenberg and Lance, 2000). RMSEA tends to over-reject a true model owing to “small sample size” and “model complexity” (Tang et al., 2006b, p. 446).

5.3 Our theoretical model of coping intelligence, satisfaction and sales commission

There are several advantages for using a formative model compared to a reflective model. In a formative model, researchers may identify whether antecedents are significantly related to the latent construct. It allows us to observe positive or negative signs between antecedents and the latent construct. A positive (negative) sign reveals that antecedent contributes positively (negatively) to the latent construct. Further, scholars may also check the correlations between and/or among all the antecedents. With pair-wise comparisons, we may detect whether one path is significantly stronger than the other path.

Our formative theoretical model of CI provided excellent results (Table III, Model 1; Figure 2). PFC positively (0.43) and EFC negatively (−0.37) defined the latent CI construct which, in turn, was positively related to job satisfaction (0.74), life satisfaction (0.59) and sales commission (0.18)[4]. PFC and EFC strategies are negatively correlated (−0.22). Owing to

a significant but small correlation (−0.22 $<$ 0.80) between the two, there was very little construct duplication or overlap. All paths were significant at 0.001 levels, except for sales commission ($p < 0.007$). Overall, CI is positively and significantly related to job satisfaction, life satisfaction and sales commission, supporting $H1$ to $H3$ and our CI theory regarding both subjective and objective outcome variables.

We treat PFC and EFC strategies as two reflective models. Three items of PFC had the following factor loadings: 0.80, 0.63 and 0.32 (Figure 2), respectively. On the basis of Figure 2, the estimated composite reliability (Raykov, 1997) based on standardized factor loadings and error variances were 0.618 and 0.60, for PFC and EFC strategies, respectively[5].

First, we set the path from CI to sales commission to be 1, which allowed us to compare the following relationships:

- between CI and life satisfaction (0.59); and
- between CI and job satisfaction (0.74).

Pairwise parameter comparisons showed that the difference between the two was *not* significant ($z = 1.630 < 1.96$).

Second, when we set the path between CI and life satisfaction to be 1, SEM results remained the same. We compared the difference between:

- the path between CI and sales commission (0.18, $p < 0.007$); and
- the path between CI and job satisfaction (0.74).

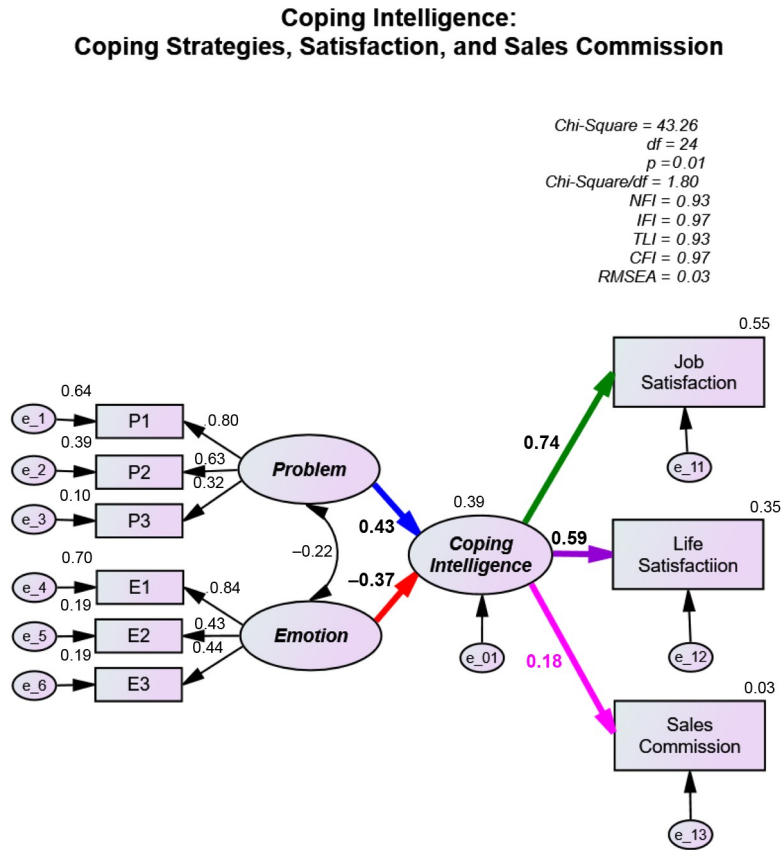
The difference was significant ($z = -7.170 > 2.58$, $p < 0.005$), suggesting that CI enhances higher job satisfaction (0.74) than sales commission (0.18).

Third, we set the path between CI and job satisfaction to be 1. The path between CI and life satisfaction (0.59) was significantly stronger ($z = -7.043 > 2.58$) than that between

Table III Results of formative theoretical model

Model	χ^2	df	p	χ^2/df	IFI	TLI	CFI	RMSEA
1. Model 1 sales commission as an outcome	43.26	24	0.01	1.80	0.97	0.93	0.97	0.03
2. Model 1 (control for gender)	44.06	24	0.00	1.84	0.97	0.92	0.96	0.03
3. Model 1 (control for performance)	45.70	18	0.00	2.54	0.95	0.87	0.95	0.04
4. Model 1 (control for performance and gender)	54.77	19	0.00	2.88	0.94	0.82	0.94	0.05

Figure 2 Results of our theoretical model



CI and commission. CI significantly enhances both *subjective* life satisfaction and job satisfaction *more* than sales commission. Finally, our objective sales commission was, indeed, a significant and powerful path (0.18, $p < 0.007$) among three outcomes. Theoretically, this concurrent validity reveals that high CI enhances *objective* sales commission (from personnel record). As sales commission represents sales revenue, we argue the following strongly: It pays to improve CI.

5.4 Control for gender

We tested our model by controlling for gender (Table III, Model 2; Figure 3)[6]. Gender (male) was significantly related to items 1-miracle (−0.16) and 3-fantasies (−0.11) of the EFC strategy (see Appendix) and sales commission (0.14). After controlling for gender, both PFC (0.43) and EFC (−0.37) contributed greatly to improve job satisfaction (0.74), life satisfaction (0.59) and sales commission (0.16). The two coping strategies were negatively correlated (−0.22). the results supported *H4*.

5.5 Control for sales commission

We removed sales commission as an outcome variable and treated it as a control variable. Sales commission was significantly correlated with life satisfaction (0.22) and job satisfaction (0.24). After controlling for salespeople's performance, the results remained significant (Table III, Model 3; Figure 4). PFC (0.44) and EFC (−0.36) greatly improve life satisfaction (0.55) and job satisfaction (0.72). The negative

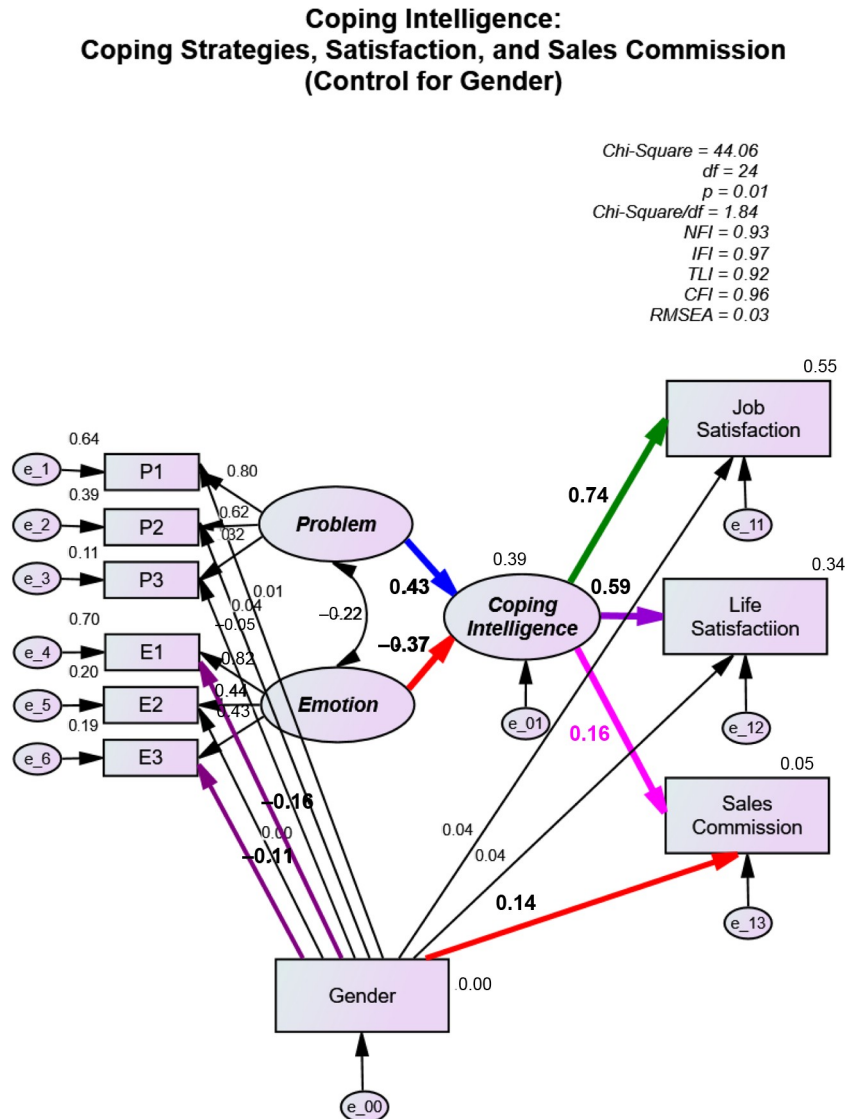
correlation between two coping strategies again existed (−0.22). The results supported *H5*.

5.6 Control for both gender and sales commission

In this analysis, sales commission was, again, positively associated with life satisfaction (0.22) and job satisfaction (0.24) and gender (female) was significantly related to two items (Item 1 = −0.15, Item 3 = −0.11) of the EFC strategy. After we controlled for both sales commission and gender, the results remained significant (Table III, Model 4; Figure 5). PFC (0.44) and EFC (−0.37) significantly improve life satisfaction (0.55) and job satisfaction (0.72). The negative correlation between two coping strategies existed. The results support all hypotheses.

6. Discussion

Our formative theoretical framework of CI explores the extent to which PFC and EFC strategies contribute differently to the CI construct, which is related to job satisfaction, life satisfaction and sales commission. On the basis of 452 boundary-spanning salespeople's survey data and their sales commission from company's personnel record, our discoveries support our CI theory: PFC contributes positively, but EFC contribute negatively to CI, which, in turn, is related to high levels of job satisfaction, life satisfaction and sales commission (concurrent validity). CI is more significantly related to higher job satisfaction and life satisfaction than to higher sales commission. Our control

Figure 3 Results of our theoretical model (control for gender)

variables, gender and salespeople's commission, offer additional insights: Gender (male) is negatively related to EFC strategies, but positively related to sales commission and unrelated to job and life satisfaction; however, sales commission is unrelated to coping strategies, but significantly related to both life satisfaction and job satisfaction. We make the following theoretical, empirical and practical implications.

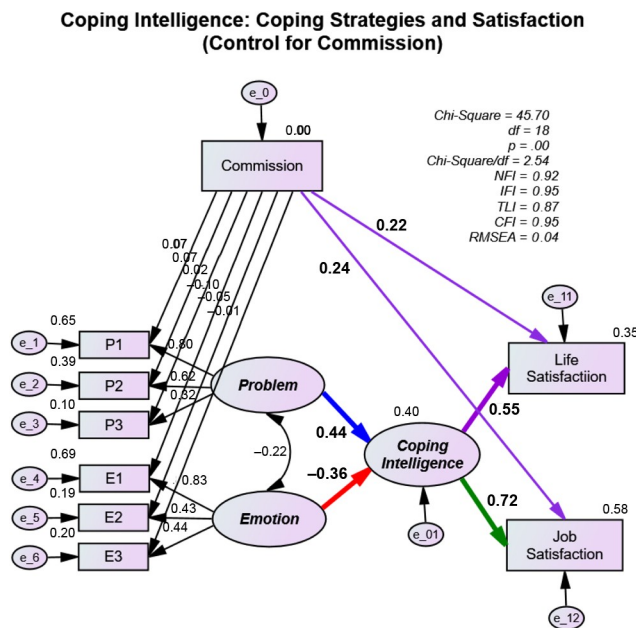
6.1 Theoretical contributions

First, our formative model helps us identify the negative correlation between PFC and EFC. Problem-focused or action-orientated, approach-oriented coping strategy solves problems and enhances satisfaction and sales commission, supporting the literature (Sardžoska and Tang, 2015). EFC or avoidance-oriented coping strategies, however, reduces job and life satisfaction and sales commission. It pays to take actions.

CI is more significantly related to job satisfaction (0.72) and life satisfaction (0.59) than increasing commission (0.18).

First, job satisfaction and life satisfaction are completely different from sales commission, representing *subjective* attitudinal scales and *objective* measures, respectively. A large sales commission signals hard cash, and a firm's large sales revenue. The relationship between CI and sales commission – an objective measure (from personnel records) establishes a very important and critical concurrent validity. Owing to this significant path and strong connections to corporations' sales revenue, it pays to enhance CI.

It takes a lot of creativity to satisfy customers and improve sales commission (Gu *et al.*, 2015; Jiang *et al.*, 2017). Creativity requires the development of novel sales strategies: increases in efficiency, effectiveness and local responsiveness to meet customer expectations and the enhancement of their service satisfaction, performance quality and sales revenue (Eisingerich *et al.*, 2014; Jiang *et al.*, 2017). Future researchers must expand our theoretical model (in its infancy) and include additional constructs to enhance our understanding and application of CI.

Figure 4 Results of our theoretical model (control for commission)

We reveal the importance of sales commission to sales personnel. Coping strategies improve sales commission. Males have higher sales commission than females, yet there are no major gender differences in life satisfaction and job satisfaction – an interesting paradox. These findings support the existing literature (Sloan and Williams, 2000). Owing to differences in gender roles and their socialization processes, we suspect that females in this study are interested in social interactions. They are not in the profession for the money. Females experience high levels of stress, frustration and EFC strategies on their jobs. More research is needed here. Most males sales people are interested in money, commission and the love of money (Tang, 1992, 2016) and may simply change jobs (voluntary turnover) to improve income (Tang et al., 2000).

Sales commission is important to salespeople's job and life satisfaction. Money enhances evaluation of life but not happiness (Kahneman and Deaton, 2010). Although less money is associated with emotional pain, increases in income beyond the \$75,000 threshold in the USA may no longer improve people's happiness. Happiness is *not* the same as satisfaction. Some argue that success makes people happy (Baumeister et al., 2003; Diener et al., 1999). Others posit that happiness leads to success (Lyubomirsky et al., 2005). Personal expressiveness, but *not* hedonic enjoyment, is a signifier of success in the process of achieving self-realization (Waterman, 1993). Happiness with meaning and purpose, eudaimonic well-being, helps individuals defy adversity (Easterlin et al., 2012; Ryan and Deci, 2001; Seligman, 2011; Tang et al., 2015, 2016; Veenhoven, 1993). Happy people experience positive emotions a majority of the time, earn higher income, show numerous adaptive characteristics and exhibit positive perceptions of self and others.

Moral leadership (Gu et al., 2015) and authentic supervisors' personal integrity and character (Tang and Liu, 2012) may enhance creativity and reduce dishonesty, respectively. When

supervisors single some specific employees out for abuse or bullying, it creates one of the most stressful phenomena in the workplace, a dysfunctional and toxic relationship, and a double whammy effect, undermining creativity (Jiang et al., 2017). Future researchers may explore these issues to enhance creativity and satisfaction among sales personnel.

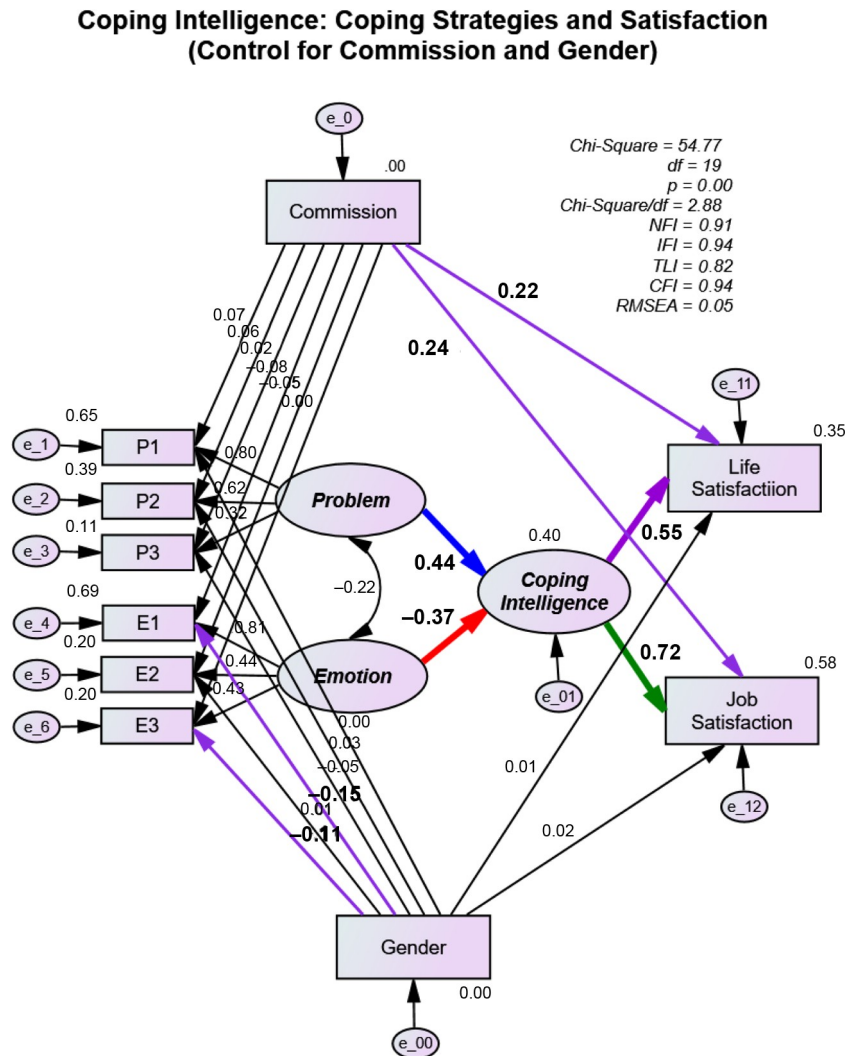
6.2 Practical contributions

Female salespeople tend to rely on EFC, reducing job and life satisfaction and commission. Clearly, hopping a miracle will happen and having fantasies that things would work out do not help females solve problems. Even removing hygiene factors will not enhance job satisfaction (Herzberg, 1987). Females have lower commission than males. Our theory offers policymakers and executives a clear option to take actions based on our novel discoveries. They may establish problem-solving groups/teams (Quality Circle – QCs); identify coping savvy employees; lead discussions related to work-related stress, coping strategies, employee satisfaction and commission; generate solutions; and improve quality of products, services and the work environment (Tang et al., 1987, 1989); and enhance sales personnel's (females in particular) commission, which is critical to the success of both the corporation and their employees. Practicing mindfulness, yoga, T'ai chi for stress management, relaxation, nutrition, religions, monotasking and social support/mentoring and employee wellness programs help employees reduce stress and enhance happiness and performance in organizations.

Happy people are more successful, have more positive emotions most of the time, earn higher income, show numerous adaptive characteristics and exhibit positive perceptions of themselves and others than their less happy counterparts (Baumeister et al., 2003; Lyubomirsky et al., 2005)[7]. Managers must help salespeople develop positive feelings (affects), increase the frequency of positive emotions, celebrate small successes frequently, improve the morale of working teams, enhance their self-esteem and promote positive attitudes toward themselves and others which may improve their sales revenue (commission) and actual performance in their jobs. In short, researchers and policymakers must improve all employees' core self-evaluations (CSE), which predicts performance on the job (Judge and Bono, 2001; Judge et al., 2003; Tang et al., 2013).

6.3 Limitation

Despite our empirical contributions, our cross-sectional data from multiple sources do *not* provide any specific cause-and-effect relationships between coping strategies and life and job satisfaction and between individuals' job satisfaction and life satisfaction and objective performance (commission). Our fit indices are excellent but only adequate for Tucker–Lewis Index in our analyses involving sales commission. Our sample with 452 boundary-spanning salespeople was small but large enough to produce robust and novel findings.

Figure 5 Theoretical model (control for gender and commission)

7. Conclusion

Our new theory of CI illustrates the following: PFC and EFC strategies contribute to CI differently, which leads to higher levels of job satisfaction, life satisfaction and sales commission. Gender (male) is related to low EFC strategies but high sales commission. Sales commission is related to job satisfaction and life satisfaction. Our theory's robust concurrent validity demonstrates that it pays to improve coping strategies in organizations. Our research reveals practical implications to business and industrial marketing.

Notes

- 1 We would like to thank an anonymous reviewer for this constructive suggestion. In our parsimonious model, inclusion of additional construct, e.g. dysfunctional coping, may lead to a high level of construct overlap and duplication. Further, model complexity and small sample size may lead to the over rejection of a true model (Tang *et al.*, 2006).
- 2 There are four types of measures: nominal (category), ordinal (order), interval (equal distance), and ratio (equal

distance with an absolute zero). Scholars use a 5-point Likert scale (equal distance) for psychological constructs—job and life satisfaction. Sales commission is a ratio scale (interval scale with an absolute zero).

- 3 Please see our Footnote 1.
- 4 We used bold (color) arrows and large fonts to indicate all significant paths.
- 5 We would like to thank an anonymous reviewer for this excellent suggestion and comment.
- 6 To control a variable (gender), an arrow emanates from the control variable to each of the indicators in our model.
- 7 The Matthew Effect: To anyone who has, more will be given and he will grow rich; from anyone who has not, even what he has will be taken away (Matthew 13: 12). See also the Parable of Talents (Matthew 25: 14-30). The Matthew Effect is a double-edged sword and creates the bright and dark sides – the rich get richer and the poor get poorer.

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Appendix. Measures of coping strategies and satisfaction

Problem-focused coping (CI-P)

- I try to work more efficiently.
- I devote more time and energy to my job.
- I decide what I think should be done and explain this to the people who are affected.

Emotion-focused coping (CI-E)

- I hope a miracle will happen.
- I try to forget the whole thing.
- Have fantasies about how things would work out.

Job satisfaction

- I find real enjoyment in my job.
- I like my job better than the average worker does.
- I am seldom bored with my job.
- I would not consider taking another job.
- Most days I am enthusiastic about my job.
- I am fairly well satisfied with my job.

Life satisfaction

- In most ways, my life is close to my ideal.
- There have been occasions when I felt like smashing things (reverse coded).
- The conditions of my life are excellent.
- I am satisfied with my life.
- So far, I have gotten the important things I want in my life.
- If I could live my life over, I would change almost nothing.

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